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COMPLETE GUIDE 03 OF 15

Zapier Automation

A practical guide with steps, examples and a checklist. Read the chapter, then build the example.

AUTOMATION · COMPLETE GUIDE

Zapier: simple automations between thousands of apps

Zapier connects apps with a Zap: one trigger, then actions. It is the quickest option when your flow is linear and you want a huge catalogue of ready connectors. This guide builds a Zap that saves Gmail attachments to Google Drive and logs them in a sheet, then explains when to move to Make or n8n.

1. The Zapier model

- **Zap** = one trigger plus one or more actions, run in order.
- **Trigger** = the event that starts a run (new email, new form entry, new row).
- **Action** = what happens next (create a file, send a message, update a row).
- **Paths** = a branch with rules, similar to a router.
- **Tasks.** Each action that runs counts as a task against your plan.

2. Worked example: invoices from Gmail to Drive and a sheet

1. **Trigger:** Gmail → New Attachment. Filter: subject contains "invoice", attachment type PDF.
2. **Action:** Google Drive → Upload File. Choose the folder `Invoices/2026`. Map the file from step 1.
3. **Action (optional, AI):** OpenAI → Send Prompt. Ask it to extract the vendor name, invoice number, date and total from the email body. Ask for JSON.
4. **Action:** Google Sheets → Create Spreadsheet Row. Map vendor, number, date, total and the Drive link.
5. **Test** with a real sample email, check each step's output, then turn the Zap on.

> **DATA CHECK**
> AI extraction is a draft. Add a Filter step after it: the total must be a number and the date must parse. Failed rows go to a "to review" sheet, not to your accounting records.

3. Paths for decisions

Use Paths when one trigger needs different actions, such as "if the sender is a client, send to CRM; otherwise, label and archive". Each path has conditions; keep the number of paths small so the flow remains readable.

4. Zapier, Make and n8n: which to choose

Need	Zapier	Make	n8n
Simple, linear flows	Best	Good	Good
Many branches and loops	Adequate	Strong	Strongest
Own server, data control	No	No	Yes
Quickest start for a non-coder	Best	Good	Learning curve

5. Checklist

- Filters on every trigger so only the right items run.
- Test data first; then one live run with a single item.
- Task count checked against your plan before you switch on a high-volume Zap.
- An owner for each Zap, and a note of what it does.

Check the current Zapier app catalogue and plan limits on the Zapier site before you rely on a specific connector.